historically and politically for the past 1,000 years. The Burman constitute approximately two-thirds of the total population of Myanmar. Many Burman (including several leaders of the country) are from mixed ancestry. It is thus difficult to speak of ethnic homogeneity in Myanmar. Since independence, the Burman have controlled the government and military structure in Myanmar. Minority populations have accused the Burman of attempting to implement a “Burmanization” policy throughout the country. Minority groups claim that they are marginalized in areas such as economics, politics, language, and education. The Burman are overwhelmingly Theravada Buddhist, and this is the main cultural characteristic that defines the group. Educationally, the Bamar language is used in the schools throughout Myanmar.

Karen

The Karens make up the second largest ethnic group in Myanmar. Demographic figures for the Karens range from 2.5 to 7 million. Ethnic Karens live throughout much of Lower Myanmar from the Arakan and delta regions to the Shan state. It is estimated that over 20 Karen subgroups are identifiable.

Many Karens fought with the British army during the colonial period. A sizeable minority of Karens also converted to Christianity by the 20th century. Nationalism among the Karen population has always been strong and friction with the majority Burman has been a constant throughout the history of Myanmar. The most significant obstacle to Karen nationalism has been geography. The Karens are dispersed throughout numerous areas of Myanmar.

Following World War II, Karen aspirations for independence increased. Immediately after the constitutional assembly, Karen militias organized and were bolstered by mass defections of ethnic Karens from the Burmese military, known as the tatmadaw. The Karen National Union was formed in 1949. The Karen movement factionalized along a communist-noncommunist line, which significantly hurt their chances for success.

Chin